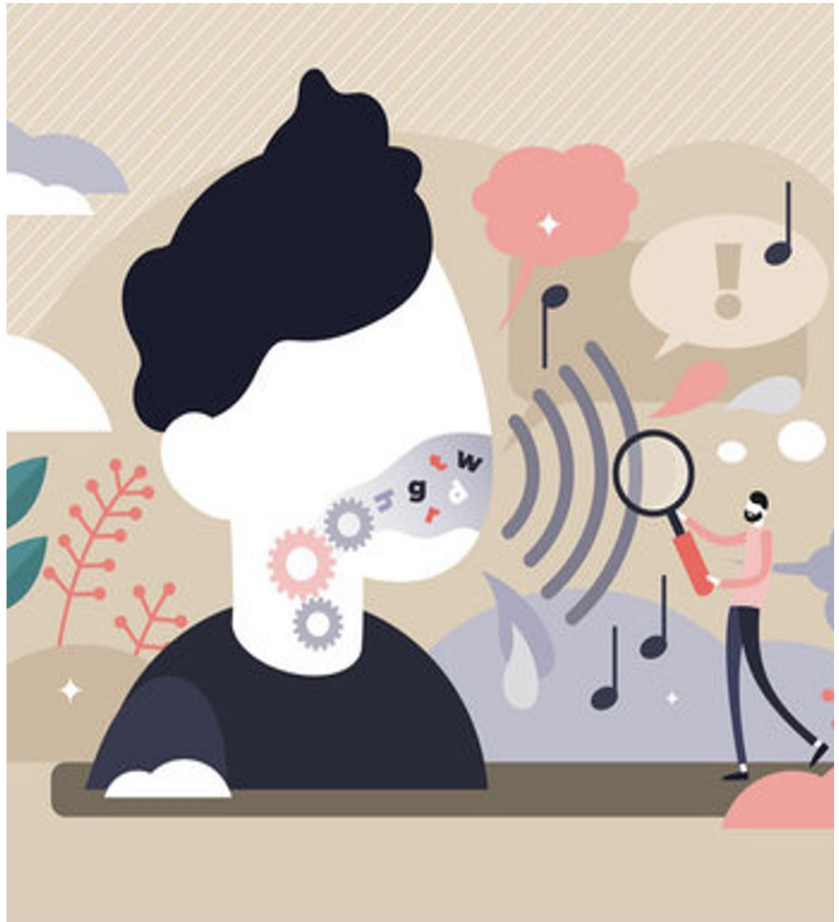
SVNIT 2024

Effective Speaking



Pronunciation: Importance of Phonetics

- A phoneme (sound unit) is a set of the smallest units of speech in a language that distinguishes one word from another, e.g., rat from cat or rot from cot.
- A phoneme is represented between slashes (/b/, /k/, /s/, etc.) by convention.
- Phonemes are divided into vowel sounds and consonant sounds. Languages can contain two to thirty vowels and five to more than 100 consonants.
- English has 44 phonemes (sounds) to the alphabet (26 letters)



https://stock.adobe.com/in/search?k=phonetics&asset_id=484269114

One-to-one correspondence between letters and phonemes does not exist in English (like in most languages).

1. some letters that can represent more than one phoneme (but only one at a time) – e.g., C in “change”, “car”, “cite.”

2. some phonemes that can be represented by alternative individual letters and/or some combination(s) of letters – e.g., ph for /f/, ch for /tʃ/, sh for /ʃ/, and so on.

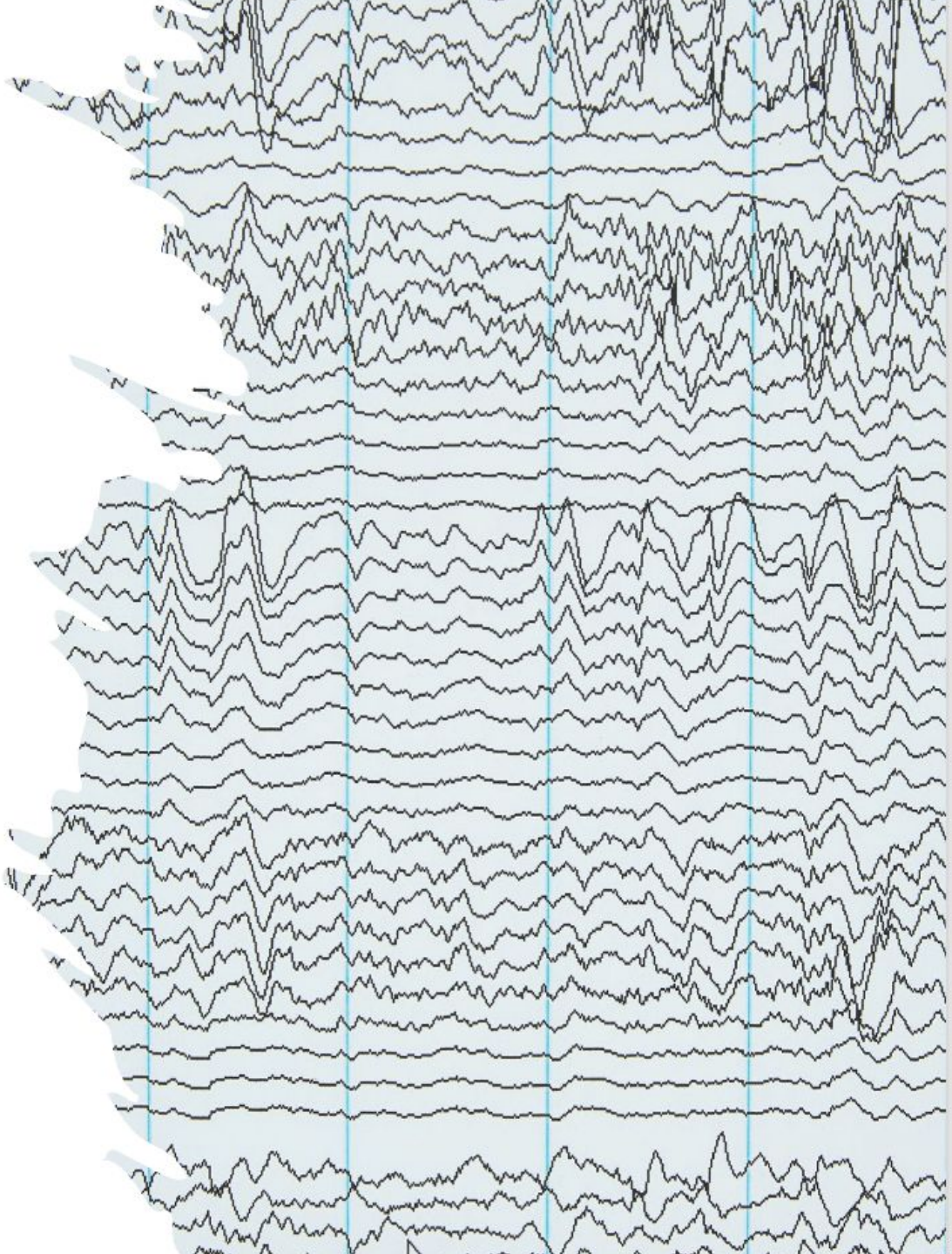
- Irregular association between sound and letter in English does not mean that there is no system of classification.
- IPA (International Phonetic Alphabet) is a system of phonetic notation devised by linguists to provide a standardized, accurate, and unique way of representing sounds of any spoken language
- IPA provides a distinct sign for each sound and is used in some dictionaries and textbooks to indicate pronunciation.

Classification of Sounds

- Oral and Nasal: depends on the release of air stream (through either mouth or nose) as the sound is produced
- Vowels and Consonants:

Vowels: The air from the lungs comes out in an unrestricted manner in a rather continuous stream.

Consonants: There is a closure of the air passage somewhere or friction between one or the other speech organ.



Vowel Sounds

Pure Vowels: single sound, quality remains steady

Diphthongs: one sound position glides to another, quality of the vowel changes

Sl. No.	IPA symbols	Words		
		Initial	Middle	Final
1.	/i:/	easy	field	see
2.	/I/	it	hill	duty
3.	/e/	enemy	step	—
4.	/æ/	apple	man	—
5.	/ɑ:/	art	mask	car
6.	/ɒ/	office	cross	—
7.	/ɔ:/	all	born	saw
8.	/ʊ/	—	book	to
9.	/u:/	ooze	fool	true
10.	/^/	under	sun	—
11.	/ɜ:/	earth	bird	stir
12.	/ə/	about	police	maker
13.	/eɪ/	eight	snail	say
14.	/əʊ/	old	hope	so
15.	/aɪ/	idea	bite	buy
16.	/aʊ/	out	sound	cow
17.	/ɔɪ/	oil	noise	boy
18.	/ɪə/	ear	hear	mere
19.	/eə/	air	hairy	share
20.	/ʊə/	—	cured	poor

The first twelve sounds are called pure vowels and the remaining eight diphthongs.

Consonant Sounds

Sl. No.	IPA symbols	Description	Words		
			Initial	Middle	Final
1.	/p/	unvoiced, oral	pen	speak	leap
2.	/b/	voiced, oral	bet	about	nib
3.	/t/	unvoiced, oral	time	better	beat
4.	/d/	voiced, oral	day	adorn	said
5.	/k/	unvoiced, oral	call	echo	ask
6.	/g/	voiced, oral	gate	ago	league
7.	/tʃ/	unvoiced, oral	church	butcher	attach
8.	/dʒ/	voiced, oral	judge	adjust	age
9.	/f/	unvoiced, oral	five	after	enough
10.	/v/	voiced, oral	vine	averse	nerve
11.	/θ/	unvoiced, oral	thin,	atheist	oath
12.	/ð/	voiced, oral	then	other	clothe
13.	/s/	unvoiced, oral	some	biscuit	cots
13.	/s/	unvoiced, oral	some	biscuit	cots
14.	/z/	voiced, oral	zoo	dozen	buzz
15.	/ʃ/	unvoiced, oral	shape	ashamed	bush
16.	/ʒ/	voiced, oral	genre	pleasure	mirage
17.	/h/	unvoiced, oral	hat	behave	ah
18.	/l/	voiced, oral	lottery	along	bottle
19.	/m/	voiced, nasal	mat	among	balm
20.	/n/	voiced, nasal	nest	sound	bin
21.	/ŋ/	voiced, nasal	—	hanging	sing
22.	/r/	voiced, oral	rest	screech	ever
23.	/w/	voiced, oral	want	question	—
24.	/j/	voiced, oral	university	student	—

Problem Sounds

Read the following exchange:

Speaker 1: Did you like the test of our copy?

Speaker 2: What do you mean? Which test and copy are you talking about?

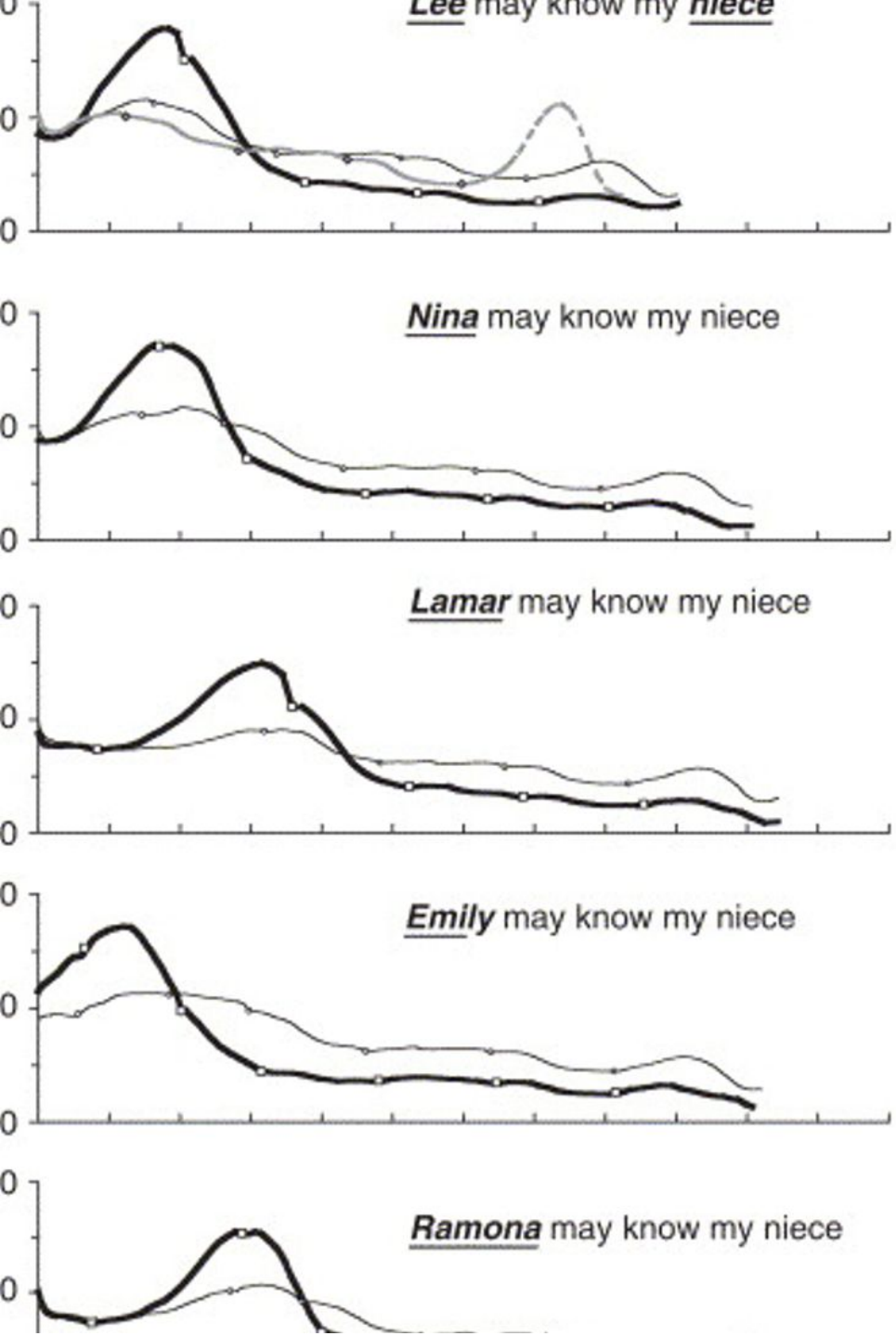
Speaker 1: The copy you have just now finished!

Speaker 2: Oh! Your coffee! It tastes so well. Thank you.

Indian speakers <u>may</u> mispronounce:

- The fricatives /f/, /v/, /q/, /ð/, /z/, /ʃ/, and /ʒ/
- Vowel glides (shown in the picture) ⟶
- Consonant clusters: School as /isku:l/ or Scheme as /iski:m/

Word	English usage	Indian usage
Date	/deɪt/	/det/
Post	/pəʊst/	/post/
Court	/kɔ:t/	/kort/
Bird	/bɜ:d/	/bəd/
Bud	/bʌd/	/bɑ:d/
Tour	/tʊə/	/tu:r/
Hurt	/hɜ:t/	/hut/
There	/ðeər/	/ðer/
Ball	/bɔ:l/	/bɑ:l/ or /bɔl/



Intonation - Patterns of Pitch Variation

- In normal speech, the pitch of our voice goes on changing constantly—going up, going down, and sometimes remaining steady.
- Different pitches of the voice combine to form patterns of pitch variation or tones, which together constitute intonation.

- Falling Tone: Questions, complete and definite sentences, command, choice questions, exclamation, negative tag in question tag,

  e.g., “What fine `weather!”

- Rising Tone: Yes/No type question, statements intended to be a question, non-terminal tone group (the first group is spoken with a rising tone while the second, polite requests/commands intended to sound like a request, tag questions with a positive tag,

  e.g., “Was he ill yesterday?”

- Falling-rising Tone: The pitch falls from high to low and then rises again to high (apology, happiness, doubt, insinuation, indirect insult, etc. and in incomplete statements).

- Rising-falling Tone: The pitch rises from low to high and then falls again to low (warmth, friendliness, anger, or sarcasm),

  e.g., Fall-rise – “Mind your v language” (Strong but sympathetic warning); Rise-fall – “Oh, really” (Sarcasm).



Confidence, Clarity, and Fluency

- Importance of delivery – brilliant ideas must get across.

  Cultivating confidence

  Working on clarity

  Developing fluency

- Developing fluency is gradual process and not only limited to speaking

  (Refer to pg. 92 *Technical Communication* by Meenakshi Raman).

Confidence

- Use fear positively.
- Given a choice, choose a topic you like.
- Constant preparation.
- Prepare some extra points in case you forget the main ones.
- Deliver a mock speech.
- Practice positive visualisation technique (requires you to concentrate on how good you are and to think all is well).
- Anticipate questions and prepare.
- Work on the introduction material.
- Do not start immediately after reaching the stage.
- Check the venue and other arrangements.
- Look at the friendliest faces in the audience.
- Do no let nervousness overpower your ideas.

Clarity

- Maintain the average number of words - not too slow, not too hasty.
- Practise exercises involving speech organs such as jaw, tongue, etc.
- Use correct pronunciation.
- Adjust volume according to the no. of audience, size of the room, availability of voice amplifying tools.
- Organise thoughts beforehand.
- Distribute the weightage of the words used.
- Use simple and unambiguous words and expressions.
- Avoid too many technical terms, acronyms, complicated words and phrases.
- Record presentations beforehand and review.

Vocal Clues

- Quality of voice: Can be worked with to reach the optimum depth and resonance.
- Volume: Can be modulated and adjusted to the need of the occasion and venue.
- Pace/Rate: Pace may vary. Pauses and Emphasis are recommended. Apt pace shows enthusiasm, self-assurance, and awareness of audience.
- Pitch: Inflections give warmth, lustre, vitality, and exuberance to our speech. Avoid raising the pitch of our voice as we end a sentence. This vocal pattern, called pitching up, makes our remarks sound tentative or unfinished.

- Articulation: Speakers should be careful not to slop, slur, chop, truncate, or omit sounds between words or sentences.
- Pronunciation: Received Pronunciation (RP) is standard.
- Voice Modulation: Speech must not fall flat. Appropriate use of stress must be made.
- Pauses: A pause in speaking helps the listener reflect on the message and digest it accordingly. But one must avoid vocalized pauses or vocal segregates such ‘as’, ‘uh’, ‘ah’, ‘hm’, ‘ahem’, or repetitive phrases such as ‘I mean’, ‘well’, ‘like’, ‘ok’, ‘got it’, ‘actually’,

Thank You